RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Every Act Counts: Principle 11

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 16

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 11 (reward and punishment)

Shiur: Part 16 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 3 February 2026

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Where We Are

Principles	
1–5	**Hashem Himself**
6–7	**Prophecy**, and **Moshe's unique prophecy**
8–9	**The Torah** is from heaven, and **will never change**
10	**Hashem knows our deeds and our thoughts**, and what **His knowledge** means
11	**Tonight.** "**I've deliberately titled the shiur *the consequences of our actions*.** You'll see why."
12–13	**Mashiach** and ***Techiyat HaMetim***: "things we've already discussed in this series," probably **together, next week**

Part 1: The Text

היסוד האחד עשר: כי הוא יתברך נותן שכר למי שעושה מצות התורה, ויעניש למי שעובר על אזהרותיה. וכי השכר הגדול העולם הבא, והעונש החזק הכרת. וכבר אמרנו בזה הענין מה שיספיק.

Hashem rewards those who keep the Torah's commandments and **punishes** those who transgress its prohibitions. **The greatest reward is Olam HaBa; the severest punishment is *karet***. (We've already said enough on this.)

והמקרא המורה על היסוד הזה מה שנאמר: "ועתה אם תשא חטאתם, ואם אין מחני נא מספרך אשר כתבת". והשיב לו השם יתברך: "מי אשר חטא לי אמחנו מספרי". ראיה שיודע העובד והחוטא, לתת שכר לזה ועונש לזה.

After **the Golden Calf**, Moshe: ***If You will bear their sin; if not, blot me out of Your book.*** Hashem: ***Whoever has sinned against Me, him I will blot out of My book.*** **Proof** that Hashem knows the server and the sinner, to **reward the one and punish the other**.

Why *this* verse?

"**There are so many verses**: **Adam** was told not to eat, ate, and was punished; **Noach's generation**; **Sodom**; **Avimelech**. **Far more explicit.** Why go to **this specific dialogue**? **It's a great proof, but there are so many before it. I believe it's the root of this principle.**" *(Answer in Part 4.)*

The Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal

	Text	Covers
Ani Ma'amin	**שהבורא יתברך שמו גומל טוב לשומרי מצותיו ומעניש לעוברי מצותיו**	**Part one only**
Yigdal	**גומל לאיש חסד כמפעלו, נותן לרשע רע כרשעתו**	**Part one only**

Both state the **main part**: **there are consequences**. **Neither includes Olam HaBa and *karet***, "**which the Rambam includes for a reason**" (Part 6).

Part 2: The Missing Principle in Hilchot Teshuvah

Hilchot Teshuvah 3 (learnt together a couple of years ago) lists **who has no portion in Olam HaBa**:

Rambam	Principle
3:7, the five *minim*: no God; **two gods**; **a body**; **not the First**; **serving *avodah zarah***	**1–5**
3:8, deniers of prophecy / of Moshe's	**6, 7**
The Torah is not from heaven (even one verse), or **Hashem has exchanged the mitzvot**	**8, 9**
Hashem doesn't know human deeds	**10**
Denying *Techiyat HaMetim* and **Mashiach**	**12, 13**
Reward and punishment	**Missing**

The commentators ask: where's Principle 11?

"**The explanation, I think, is simple:** it's **a follow-on from Principle 10**. **Hashem's knowledge of our actions is only relevant if there are consequences.** *So He knows: so what?* **Eleven is what 10 means.**"

Part 3: Everything Is Just: The Moreh and the Me'iri

Moreh III:17: ומכלל יסודי תורת משה רבנו שלא יתכן מלפניו יתעלה עול בשום אופן, ושכל האסון הבא על בני אדם או הטובה המגעת להם, יחיד או ציבור, הכל כפי הדין ומשפט צדק שאין בו עול כלל. אפילו נדקר אדם מקוץ בידו והוציאו מיד, הרי זה עונש עליו... אלא שאיננו יודעים כיצד הוא הדין.

No injustice from Hashem in any way. Every misfortune or good, **to an individual or a community**, is **just**: **even a thorn in the hand pulled out at once** is a consequence. **We just don't know *how* the judgement works.**

The Me'iri (Shabbat 55): *"Not a direct student of the Rambam, about a hundred years later, but he shared his outlook and often followed him."*

מכרע הדת להאמין שכל מה שיקרה לאדם מטוב ועד רע, הכל מושגח מאת השם יתברך בפרטות: everything that happens to a person, good to bad, is under particular providence. Don't be put off by **righteous people suffering and the wicked prospering**: **אין הקב״ה מקפח שכר כל בריה.**

Chazal: אין מיתה בלא חטא ואין יסורין בלא עון: no death without sin, no suffering without iniquity. The Rambam emphatically brings this: the correct understanding.

But what about…

Statement	Seems to say	The Me'iri
Bava Batra 17a / Shabbat 55b: four people died only through the serpent's counsel (Adam's sin)	**Death without sin**	***Derech haflagah***: **exaggeration. They sinned very little**
Kohelet 7:20: אין אדם צדיק בארץ אשר יעשה טוב ולא יחטא	**Everyone sins**	Not literal either: **no one avoids even a small sin**

(Rav Saadia, learnt on Monday nights, was also bothered by Kohelet: he read it as no one lacks the ability *to sin. "But the simple meaning is no one doesn't sin.")*

The Me'iri's key line: ואף על פי שנשאר דעת האומר כן בתיובתא, אין עיקרי אמונות תלויים בראיות של פשטי מקראות ואגדות.

Principles of faith don't hang on the plain sense of individual verses and aggadot. "Beautiful. Don't build philosophy and theology on individual statements of Chazal." The general rule stands: everything is a consequence of one's own deeds.

Part 4: "Reward and Punishment" Is the Wrong Picture

"**I've been using the phrase *reward and punishment*, but the truth is it's really a Christian idea. We don't really have that concept**, and I'll prove it."

"**Many religious people think Olam HaBa and Gehinnom are places where you get rewarded and punished.** Some have a **very crude** understanding. **And truth be told, some Chachamim believed that**: on Monday nights we **just finished *Emunot veDe'ot***: **Rav Saadia** sees **Gehinnom as a kind of fire** and **Olam HaBa as a kind of light**. **We struggled with it. I reject it, only because I have the Rambam, who explained it far more deeply.**"

For the Rambam there's no principle called "reward and punishment". Principle 11 is: Hashem responds to our choices. Principle 10: Hashem knows what we do, **and we have choice**. Principle 11: **there are repercussions to what we do with that choice.**

Middah keneged middah

Usually translated **"measure for measure"** or **"tit for tat"**: "*you do X, Hashem gives you Y; you do good, He gives you gold coins*.**"** The deeper idea:**

"In this world a person creates his or her own identity."

That's the key point to remember from tonight.

This world	The next world
The world of process: choices, **doing**, **forming identity**	**No longer achieving, but existing** on **the identity you made**
"**A kind of simulation** of our real identity, which **we can change** while we can choose"	**Our real identity, fully realised and felt**

Shabbat: one-sixtieth of Olam HaBa

"**So many explanations, but I think it's simpler. ששת ימים תעבד ועשית כל מלאכתך… וביום השביעי תשבת. The six days are human *doing*; Shabbat is human *being*. We stop achieving and just exist in the moment.**"

"**That's why the halachah forbids preparing on Shabbat for after Shabbat**: start preparing and **you're thinking about next week**, **not living in the moment**."

"**Exactly what Olam HaBa is: the world of existing**, on the essence you made of yourself here."

Olam HaBa is a shared space between Hashem and us: **true existence**, **who we really are**.

The Ramchal, opening of *Mesillat Yesharim*: שהאדם לא נברא אלא להתענג על ה׳ ולהנות מזיו שכינתו, שזהו התענוג האמיתי והעידון הגדול מכל העידונים שיכולים להמצא. ומקום העידון הזה באמת הוא העולם הבא… אך הדרך כדי להגיע אל מחוז חפצנו זה, הוא זה העולם.

Man was created to delight in Hashem and bask in the radiance of His presence, the greatest bliss. **Its place is Olam HaBa; the way there is this world. "Simple as that.**"

"**Our reward isn't a bag of gold coins for our trouble, and our punishment isn't a smack for being bad. It's simply what I've chosen for myself.**" *Sechar* and *onesh* = **the repercussions of a person's choices**.

Back to the verse: nothing is transferable

"**That's why the Rambam chose this verse.** Moshe offers: **take their sin, or blot *me out*. Hashem:*** Whoever has sinned against Me, him I will blot out*. It doesn't work like that. Reward and punishment can't be transferred, because it's who you are**."

"With Adam, Noach, Sodom you might picture **a system**: they sinned, so **God punished**. **The Rambam says: don't think like that.**"

"**In some circles you'll find: *do a mitzvah on my behalf*, *sell me the value of your mitzvah*, *say Kaddish for my father and I'll pay you***. **Each has its own context**, but generally **the Rambam would frown on all of these. That's not how Torah works.**"

Part 5: *Tzaddik, Rasha* and the Fair Question

Start point: כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא: "**that's how we're created to be**." **How much** of that shared existence we have is **commensurate with who we become**. "**The only thing Hashem won't do is make the choices for us.**"

Who is a *rasha*?

"People picture **an evil person with fangs**. **It doesn't have to be like that.**"

	Rasha	***Tzaddik***
Lives for	**The moment**: **no memory, no past**, no identity **beyond the whims of now**	**The long game**
Has	**No purpose, direction, future, goals**	**Thinks of the future** and **makes the right choice for it**
Model	**Esav**	**Yaakov**

Why Chazal make Esav and Yaakov *the stereotypes, when "in the Torah Yaakov has questionable moments and Esav good ones": the lentil stew. Esav comes home hungry and tired*:* feed me***. Yaakov:*** sell me the birthright***. Esav:*** הנה אנכי הולך למות ולמה זה לי בכרה*. "**The whim of the moment.** Yaakov **works hard cooking** and **plays the long game**, **always**."

Karet

The greatest punishment, *karet*: you don't share this existence with God. אין לו חלק לעולם הבא.

The Rambam (Hilchot Teshuvah 8:5): הנקמה שאין נקמה גדולה ממנה, שתכרת הנפש ולא תזכה לאותן החיים.

Sechar mitzvah mitzvah (Avot 4:2)

Many commentators try to explain it. **The Rambam explains it**: **the** "שכר מצוה מצוה, ושכר עבירה עבירה. **reward of a mitzvah is the mitzvah itself**: it **creates the person I am**. **The result of a sin is the sin itself**: **you've tarnished yourself**. **There's no *you went against My word, so I'll hurt you***".

Sinners who aren't *resha'im*

"**Many people commit many sins**, even **terrible** things, **but deep down they care**: they **know, believe, want to do good**, but **they get stuck in muck**. **That's not a *rasha*.** They **have a vision of Olam HaBa** and **a place in it**; they keep getting stuck."

"Is it fair?" The kind atheist

"**I've been asked this so many times.** *He's so kind, so moral, so good, so clever, but an atheist. No portion in the world to come?***"

Through the lens of…	**Answer**
Reward and punishment	"**Doesn't make sense.** Why such a big punishment for a great person?"
Identity	"**Makes total sense. How can you share a space with something you don't believe in?** You **lived your life with an identity that denied any existence beyond you**, so **you don't live with that existence when you die**."

("This, by the way, is what Yom Kippur is all about": we've discussed it in the past.)

"Then why does Hashem get angry?"

?**His nostrils burn**. If consequences are **natural**, why speak like this :(in the Shema) **וחרה אף ה׳ בכם**

דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם. "**We're meat brains**."

"**A good parent's anger** isn't **revenge**, nor **punishing the child for the wrong**. **Correct anger says: I have a vision for who you are; I'm trying to mould you; you're not living up to it, and I want you to see I'm upset.**" **So too Hashem: I want you to share existence with Me, and you're not.**

Part 6: Not a Candy Machine

Avot 1:3, Antigonos: אל תהיו כעבדים המשמשין את הרב על מנת לקבל פרס.

Why *peras*, a *prize*, and not *sachar*?

	***Peras*, a prize**	**"Rewarding"**
At work	**The salary and the bonuses**	"**My job has been rewarding**": **the fruits**, **something beyond the financial**
In avodat Hashem	**"I put in X, press a button, coins come out"**	**Who I become**

"**People who serve for a prize treat Hashem as a candy machine, a gold-coin machine. That's where all these *segulot* come from**: *say this verse twice on that day, then repeat it, and you'll get money*."

The Tuesday of Parashat Beshalach

"**Last week you were probably bombarded**: *say Parashat HaMan twice today, there's a* segulah *for the Tuesday of Beshalach*."

"**There *is a 'segulah', in inverted commas, to say Parashat HaMan every day: it's recorded in the Shulchan Aruch. But the idea isn't mystical magic. It reminds you that parnassah comes from Hashem. Go to work with that in mind, live like that, and of course Hashem gives you hashgachah pratit, because, as we learnt last week, the more you live with Hashem, the more providence you have."***

"But only at this hour, on the ninth hour of the ninth day of the eleventh: **it doesn't work like that. Certainly not in the Rambam's world.**"

Why the Rambam includes Olam HaBa and *karet* in the principle

"**It's not enough to believe in reward and punishment if you think of it in an immature, crude way. That's wrong.** It means **an identity that exists with Hashem**, or **one that doesn't**. **That's what *sechar va'onesh* mean.**"

Part 7: Is There Reward in This World?

On the Rambam's account, the reward can only be in Olam HaBa. Chazal say clearly: **there's no reward for mitzvot in this world** (**שכר מצוה בהאי עלמא ליכא**).

But we say every morning: אלו דברים שאדם אוכל פירותיהם בעולם הזה והקרן קיימת לו לעולם הבא.

The Rambam: those aren't reward; they're *perot*, fruits. Help from Hashem **to live the best life here**: **encouragement, guidance, support**, so that you're **not preoccupied with money or health** and **can focus on building your identity**.

"**Other Rishonim disagree.** But on the Rambam's view of Olam HaBa, **reward in this world is philosophically impossible**. **You can't pay me off with extra money or extra years.** You may get them, **to support you** in creating the best identity."

Not a checklist

"**So easy to fall into the trap**: *I put on tefillin, learn my Torah, go to my shiur, pray, say my Tehillim: tick, and I get my reward.* **Of course we keep doing all of it**, but **with the idea that the more I do, the more I develop who I am**."

The Rambam's two axes, everywhere: character (*middot*, moral perfection) and **intellect** (Torah and all study).

Why doesn't the Torah mention Olam HaBa?

With Rav Saadia we saw several reasons; **Ibn Ezra**: **people can't grasp it**; there are many **hints**, nothing explicit.

For the Rambam, the question doesn't begin. "If Olam HaBa were **a prize**: *why not mention the prize?* **Everyone asks.**" But **the Torah is the guide to living well**, and **Olam HaBa is the natural outcome of the identity it builds**. "**When you do the mitzvot, *that* is Olam HaBa.** You're making yourself the best person: **the greatest reward, full stop. It fits so beautifully.**"

Summary

1. **Principle 11:** Hashem **rewards and punishes**; **the greatest reward is Olam HaBa, the severest punishment *karet*. Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal** give only the first part.
2. It's **missing from Hilchot Teshuvah 3's list** because it's **the consequence of Principle 10**.
3. **Everything that happens is just** (Moreh III:17; **the Me'iri**): **אין מיתה בלא חטא**. Contrary aggadot are **exaggeration**; **principles of faith don't rest on individual statements**.
4. **"Reward and punishment" is a crude, Christian-sounding frame** (and **Rav Saadia's fire and light**). **The Rambam: *middah keneged middah* means you create your own identity.**
5. **This world is process, the next is existence**: **Shabbat, one-sixtieth of Olam HaBa**; **the Ramchal**.
6. **The verse of the Golden Calf**: **you can't transfer merits or sins**.
7. **The *rasha lives for the moment (Esav); the tzaddik plays the long game (Yaakov).** Karet = *no shared existence**. **The kind atheist** makes sense once you see it as **identity**.
8. **Antigonos's *peras*: not a candy machine**; *segulot* such as **Parashat HaMan** work by **reminding** us, not by magic.
9. **This world gives only *perot*, support** for the real goal. **The Torah needn't mention Olam HaBa**: **keeping it *is* Olam HaBa**.

Coming Up

Next week: Principles 12 and 13, Mashiach and *Techiyat HaMetim*, "**probably together**." Then, "in a couple of weeks," **Moreh Nevuchim** on Tuesday nights. **Next Monday:** the *sefer* of the Rambam's son, ***HaMaspik LeOvdei Hashem***.

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